

Review Article

How to conduct a focus group interview: Tips, strategies, and examples for novice researchers

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The focus group interview is a strategy that researchers use across all disciplines from marketing to education and cultural studies. Facilitating a focus group interview is challenging even for experienced researchers. This paper shares the authors' perspectives on the focus group interview with arguments from the literature along with practical applications. The authors use examples from several of their research studies to discuss a scholarly yet practical approach to plan, conduct, and analyze successful focus groups for the intended audience of doctoral students. In addition to suggestions for facilitating data collection and data analysis for the focus group interview, this paper includes strategies to select the participants, ensure participants show up, engage all the focus group participants, address powerful or authoritative personalities, enhance the synergy of the group, and reach consensus.

Keywords: Focus group interview, planning, conducting, interviewing, data analysis, participant selection, powerful or authoritative personalities, power dynamics, triangulation, member checking

1. Introduction

A focus group interview is a flexible, unstructured dialogue between the members of a group and an experienced facilitator/moderator that meets in a convenient location; the location can be face-to-face or virtual. The focus group interview is a way to elicit multiple perspectives on a given topic (Packer-Muti, 2010; Rosenthal, 2016; Then et al., 2014; Vala, 2014). A focus group is an effective strategy to gather a great deal of data in a short amount of time (Coule, 2013), and an excellent tool to gather multiple perspectives about a given phenomenon (Wagner et al., 2016). One could use a focus group interview to reach data saturation if a large pool of potential participants were drawn from (Hancock et al., 2016). This would be appropriate if a researcher conducted individual interviews with a small number of participants to gain a group perspective about the phenomenon (George, 2013). For example, after interviewing

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five senior executive level leaders individually, one could interview 5–8 more senior executive level leaders as a group. It may be relative to a study to capture an individual perspective as well as a group perspective (Dilshad & Latif, 2013). Planning the focus group event takes consideration of many factors: selecting and securing participants, reviewing the informed consent form with participants, considering the focus group interview setting, and the number of participants needed to collect the data. The role of the researcher is to collect, organize, and interpret the data from the focus group interview.

2. Planning

Planning a focus group is vital to ensuring the best possible outcome of the event. Long- and short-term goals help the researcher conduct a success focus group. Long-term planning, which can be initiated several weeks or months before the event, must address the 5 Ws used by many event planners (*Who, What, When, Where, and Why*). *Who* will you invite to the focus group? *What* is the specific location that will be used and is it accessible to all participants? *When* will the event take place? *Where* will the event take place – in person or online? *Why* are you asking a specific population to the event, and do they have special needs?

Researchers should consider arriving at the location of the focus group to ensure lighting, temperature, and the location is appropriate for the participants. Ideally, the focus group leader should take a few moments to prepare the audio devices, locate additional batteries or electrical outlets as necessary, review the list of participants, and reread the focus group interview questions before participants arrive. A purposeful sampling strategy may allow the researcher an opportunity to select the appropriate research participants (Hall et al., 2019), and the informed consent form can help the participants know exactly what is expected of them.

2.1. *Selecting participants and informed consent*

Selecting participants for a study is an important step in the research process. Careful consideration should be given to the objective of the research and the desired outcomes when selecting participants. If the participants are from the same organization and same geographic locality, this may limit the originality of experiences, perceptions, and meanings collected in the study. However, having common participant characteristics can be helpful with ensuring that participants have experienced the phenomenon presented in the study.

When selecting participants, it is always a good plan to be upfront and open with potential focus group participants. Inform them as to how much time the focus group will take, so that they are aware of the process and what they are expected to provide. Be transparent about what is needed from the participants, so they know what is

expected of them and that they are agreeing to it. In a formal sense, this should be covered in the consent form that they sign.

Qualitative researchers must require focus group participants to sign an informed consent form. The purpose of the informed consent is to provide the participants with an understanding for the need for the research (Hall et al., 2019). In addition, the consent form provides any review board involved in the research an awareness of the participants understanding of the research study, along with the purpose and processes involved in the study (Marshall & Rossman, 2016). Each participant must agree to voluntarily participate in the focus group session. Participants can withdraw from a study at any time and for any reason without penalty (Gainotti et al., 2016; Marshall & Rossman, 2016).

2.2. *On site focus groups*

When conducting a focus group at a job site, ideally, one would include keeping the setting private and absent from distractions such as incoming phone calls, people coming into get important documents signed, subordinates leaving for lunch, and other various diversions and interruptions. The setting can be just as important as the questions asked to the participants. We believe that as researchers we get too involved in trying to get the data we need and then miss the opportunity to foster an exchange that may elicit the information we need in an easier manner. To avoid missing these opportunities it is suggested to use conversation prompts. A prompt is a statement or question the researcher makes and then allow the participants to take the lead in the discussion, and if needed, direct the conversation back to the topic if it becomes derailed. Other prompts to use could be asking the participants to think back to their experiences from the past or asking general to specific prompts. This type of prompting can foster a permissive interview climate where the data will naturally flow from the group.

Extraction implies control of one over the other, which Bernard (2011) cautioned against because of the concern over controlling the responses of the participants and missing important information. Extraction can be particularly important in a focus group and when interviewing participants about sensitive subjects (Uribe-Jongbloed, 2014) where a more nuanced approach is the better choice. For example, the facilitator “works at getting the group to gel and getting members to feel that they are part of an understanding cohort of people” (Bernard, 2005, p. 238). The idea is to *not* allow the facilitator of the focus group or the other participants to answer the questions for a focus group member, but rather allow them the opportunity to speak for themselves.

2.2.1. *Groupthink*

A focus group session that elicits useful information can be dependent on the skills of the facilitator as well as the failure to monitor subgroups within the focus group (Onwuegbuzie et al., 2010). Janis (1972) illustrated this process by using the Bay of Pigs fiasco, calling it a “hard hearted action by soft-headed groups” (p. 12).

Groupthink, he wrote, is the application of influence on others within the group, whereby the group itself puts enormous pressure on its individuals to conform to group standards regardless of moral judgement. Although seen by some to be dated, because of declining conformity in recent times, nevertheless, current application uses the importance of identifying barriers to change in the workplace.

Researchers should strive to avoid groupthink, which can potentially be avoided from the start. Focus group facilitators may consider rewording the interview question to gain new participant perceptions of the event. Another strategy to consider is to have the participants write their answers in a few bullet points on an individual dry erase board or piece of paper. After these points have been written, the author will proceed with the group discussion in having the participants show their bullet points to the group, and then extrapolate within the discussion itself. This strategy, as used many times in both educational and organizational settings by a seasoned researcher, additionally allows for the author to redirect the participant back to their initial bullet point foundations, and away from the group mentality as warranted.

2.2.2. Power dynamics

Power dynamics emerge in a focus group when different personalities and backgrounds exchange ideas with the facilitator and other participants in the group. The facilitator of the focus group may be viewed as having power over the group. Ayrton (2018) noted the importance of power dynamics in a focus group and said, “Although power is not centralised, an integrative approach to content and interaction implies allowing sufficient space for it to be expressed” (p. 325). The facilitator can help in making all participants feel comfortable and safe within their differing views by validating them and supporting their different views, opinions, and experiences (Canipe, 2020). Allowing the participants to have a voice in the discussion is productive and allows the collection of important data.

2.2.3. Academic setting

When conducting a focus group with educators in an academic setting such as a high school for example, it is pertinent to consider the possibility of a teacher’s schedule changing. It is also important to check, on the day of the impending interviews, if the prescheduled location is still available (and is set up appropriately). In school settings, it is not uncommon for schedules, rooms, and technology to be changed, used, or rearranged. When one author walked into the interview room, that was preset and checked the previous day, there were no teachers to be found. There were however, a small group of high school students fanatically debating with lunches in hand, and much to the author’s dismay, the entire room was rearranged according to their need. Half of the teachers that were to be interviewed that day at lunch, were inadvertently placed on lunch duty at the time of the interview; and the teacher resource room that was set up the day before for the interview, equipped with audio-video, and a group table, with convenient seclusion, was being used by the student government team when the researcher arrived. When conducting a focus group interview in an academic setting, be ready for the unexpected and have alternative plans put in place.

2.3. Number of participants

For focus groups it is recommended that the size of the group include between six and 12 participants, so that the group is small enough for all members to talk and share their thoughts, and yet large enough to create a diverse group (Lasch et al., 2010; Onwuegbuzie et al., 2010).

Researchers may opt for more participants when asking fewer questions. Onwuegbuzie et al. (2010) discovered smaller group settings could increase comfort levels of participants, which could improve their willingness to provide more thorough answers. Individuals using this method could promote more detailed answers to the questions by allowing each participant enough time to provide a complete answer.

One author had a difficult time recruiting individual interview participants. The study included a focus group and individual interview sessions. The author conducted the focus group session and used a snowball sampling technique, which is based on the referral of individuals who were previously interviewed (Marshall & Rossman, 2016). It was initially difficult to recruit individual interview participants as the study topic was team building. It was divulged to the researcher that past team building efforts in the organization had fallen short of organizational need and employees were leery to participate in a focus group to discuss this perceived failure. Once the focus group was carried out, the researcher was then able to use snowball sampling to recruit those in the organization that had an initial trust foundation with those who participated in the focus group. Because the trust building discussions within the focus group itself, the individuals that were recruited by the snowball approach were sought out by those willing to participate in the individual interviews. The combined collaboration in seeking those willing to discuss the topic, further based on trust foundation, gave an initiative to improved insight for the organization, and to those who participated in the interviews. As a result, this dynamic, based upon the use of snowball sampling, enabled those employees in the organization to better conceptualize and understand their past team building efforts in looking to a new and positive perspective.

Incentives to participate in studies are commonly used. One of the most difficult age group spans to incentivize are adolescents and young adults. Adolescents and young adults need to be approached differently, and it is important for the researcher to make this group feel like their opinions and participation in the study are valued. According to Adler et al. (2019), grouping to developmental age in a focus group is essential to prompt discussion and familiarization with others in the focus group environment. The adolescent and young adult feels safer and is more eager to express their opinion if group members are familiar to them. This developmental age group seeks an understanding of their thoughts and feelings from their peers. They also want to understand their peers' perspectives. Being in a focus group with a similar age range allows this developmental level to have a shared understanding and a unique opportunity to be heard. Being heard is paramount as it allows one of the most

important aspects of this stage of development to come to the forefront in the group setting. The need to have shared thoughts and feelings allows adults who are leading the focus group to have an insightful foundation to discover the meaning of events from the perspective of those in the focus group (Kennedy et al., 2001). Therefore, being heard and hearing others is vital to the success of an adolescent and young adult focus group.

One author used online gift cards as incentives for these age groups. The participants were given a choice as to which gift card they preferred for their participation (Catering to the age, for example-iTunes, Door Dash, Starbucks, Online Gaming). The participants then choose the card in advance, and once the study was over, the emailed gift card was immediately generated to their email inbox to be used.

Another strategy that we have used to ensure that enough participants show up for the focus group interview is to (a) first invite more participants than needed, such as 15–18 people to actually have six–12 show up; (b) send a reminder to participants a week ahead of time; and (c) personally call or meet each participant a few hours before the focus group interview to remind them what information is looked forward to their input. Using these techniques, we have facilitated numerous successful focus groups in the appropriate settings.

2.4. The focus group session

Focus group sessions are typically 90 minutes in length (Ochieng et al., 2018), depending on how dynamic the session is. Keep in mind that participants are usually very busy people, so a 90-minute session is asking a lot. It may be useful to include a pilot test for the focus group interview protocol to gain an estimate of the length of the interviews. When recruiting participants, it is a good idea to discuss with them how much time the focus group may take. This includes member checking and any other follow up data collection methods that will be used such as follow up interviews transcript review, or a debriefing session.

The focus group leader should ensure all participants have the opportunity to hear and speak comfortably. For the in-person focus group setting, leaders may consider seating the participants as they enter the venue to where the interviews will take place. By seating the participants, confusion that can occur when coming into an unfamiliar setting may be avoided and can aide in addressing any special accommodations that may be needed.

Another focus group that was conducted in an online setting included a member that wished to participate in the group; however, this individual had anxiety in using the online platform. After discussing their comfort level, the author instituted a blocked style audio-visual format in which the individuals in the online focus group were able to see one another at the same time. This format allowed for accommodations to be made on behalf of the initially uncomfortable participant and permitted all participants to freely speak and clearly be heard in the non-traditional group setting.

3. Conducting focus groups

Conducting a focus group includes knowing when to interject in the conversation, and when to listen and take notes. It is always a good idea to bring the discussion back to the focus group interview questions if the interview is going off topic. Some participants like to pontificate, as a rule; therefore, an abrupt change back to the focus group interview questions can unsettle them enough so that one can hijack the conversation back to the topic at hand. Another point to make here would be that one should not be too hasty to change the topic, as serendipitous information may emerge. To be sure, a wandering conversation is tedious and sometimes new and exciting nuggets of information are presented that can add to the depth of the data that is collected. The challenge is how to ascertain what is superfluous and what is informative. Having said that, consider hiring an experienced focus group facilitator who can direct the questioning during the session. In that way, one can sit back, take notes, and observe the interactions among the participants which can be difficult to do if when leading a session.

One issue that will often occur is when subordinates are in a focus group with their supervisor/manager or when the employment level of the participants is not equal. An example of this was when a manager is in a focus group with the employees even if the employees do not report to the manager, the employees are anxious about providing input in front of the managers. Therefore, researchers should strive to have focus groups participants equal in rank. One author experienced a good example of the participants not wanting to talk when three focus groups were structured in a study of employee performance and culture in a small manufacturing company with 101 employees. The three focus groups included (a) one comprising production hourly workers, (b) one comprising leads and supervisors of the hourly workers, and (c) one comprising of office hourly workers. The three groups were homogeneous in rank; however, there was an interesting event that occurred during the production hourly worker focus group.

All three focus groups began well except for the production hourly worker focus group. During the first 20 minutes while the production hourly worker participants were eating, the author chatted with each person so that they were comfortable and ready to start. Within the first 5 minutes of starting the formal focus group session, the company president dropped in to wish all well. It was clear that the president wanted to show his support for the research; however, the workers immediately stopped participating. After the company president left, the participants were anxious and not comfortable sharing their perspectives. To overcome this anxiety and encourage participation, the author asked a hypothetical question: If the president told you tomorrow morning that he was leaving on a world trip for a year and you are in charge of the company, what would you do? One worker immediately responded that he would give everyone a 10% raise; the author asked: Only 10%? After some laughter, the group overcame their anxiety and actively participated. This example demonstrated the importance of having participants all at the same level for a workplace focus group.

3.1. Recording the interviews

A key factor in a focus group interview session is to capture the answers to the interview questions. One author instructed participants to pass the audio recorder to the next participant when he or she was finished with their response to the question. The audio recorder was passed from participant to participant, which appeared as a silent indicator as to which participant had the opportunity to provide their answer. The focus group participants followed the silent indicator, yet occasionally asked for an opportunity to use the voice recorder out of turn to provide a clearer answer. Another method is to provide a second voice-recording device from a stationary point in the room in the case of a malfunction or human error (Hall et al., 2019). Once the interview is over, the original data collected can never be fully recovered if a failed recording occurs, as was the case for one of the authors.

3.2. Interviewing techniques

Scholars may consider observing focus group interview sessions to determine the best process based on their group. Experienced focus group facilitators may provide tips before or after the session. Additionally, the scholar may want to observe a focus group in setting that is familiar to the environment in that they are going to facilitate their focus group. One author observed a focus group in a hospital setting and gathered insight on the process of interviewing and an understanding about the medical professionals and the administrative culture in which the interviews were going to take place. Understanding the interactions, and the setting allowed for greater foundation for the preparation of the focus group interview. However, it is important to see the interaction of the participants and focus group leader for a better understanding of how to keep the conversation moving forward. Focus groups have limitations pertaining to a propensity for groupthink in that members may pressure others to conform to a group consensus (Dimitroff et al., 2005).

3.2.1. Interview language

The interview questions will allow the collection of data needed to answer the central research question (Hall et al., 2019). The participants must understand the focus group questions to answer the questions. Moreover, the focus group participants may provide a deeper level of response given the ease of the interview question. The language of the open-ended interview questions should include terminology the participant will understand. Researchers use open-ended interview questions to obtain the data necessary and gain the perspectives and opinions of the participants (Yin, 2018). One would avoid asking closed-ended questions, or those questions that could include a “yes” or “no” answer.

An individual participant had a question about a specific three-word phrase in one of the author’s focus group sessions. The focus of the study included the phrase, which was intended to identify the specific problem of the qualitative case study.

The third participant in the focus group session realized the questionable phrase and defined the phrase before providing his answers. The focus group participants answer appeared to provide a deeper response for the remaining focus group participants who had not answered the interview question.

Focus group interview questions are written with the interviewee in mind. One would write a question in one way to interview a teenager and another way to interview the Queen of England, for example. It is all about the perspective and worldview of the participant. There are many challenges and concerns regarding interviewing participants. Hearing and understanding the perspective of others may be one of the most difficult dilemmas that face the researcher (Fields & Kafai, 2009). The use of jargon and insider wording can make it difficult, if not impossible, for researchers to ascertain what the participant *means* (Brett et al., 2007).

3.2.2. *Body language*

Remember to consider body language, as we all communicate more than we may intend through our body language (Denham & Onwuegbuzie, 2013; Tecau & Tescasiu, 2015). Nonverbal communication is important to understand the full meaning of a participant's response (Denham & Onwuegbuzie, 2013). It is easy to misunderstand what is meant when the researcher does not know the cultural context (Abolafia, 2010). Some body language and cultural foundations encourage yet can discourage a participant in a group setting.

A woman who was from a small farming town in southern France was taught not to speak in a formal group setting, unless prompted to speak or questioned by another in the group. This cultural behavior in a group setting was taught to her in primary school. It was reiterated in her home environment. Therefore, when the author in the small and intimate focus group did not hear from this participant, the author asked her why she was not participating in the focus group discussion. The woman shyly stated that it was not proper for her to speak unless spoken to, or if a question was asked of her. At that point, the author realized the discomfort and mores of the participant, and the impending ramification of the cultural context of group discussion. The author then immediately restructured the format to be sure to consciously prompt and seek out answers from this participant. In this focus group setting, the cultural ramifications of capturing answers became a limitation in the study itself.

During the focus group interview phase, the facilitator could ask the participants what is meant by a certain insider term, and followup questions during member checking can ascertain a meaning. Member checking can go a long way towards enhancing the validity of the results of a study and building a rapport with the participants when the researcher demonstrates interest in what they have to say (Brett et al., 2007). Experienced facilitators know how to mitigate people with powerful and authoritative personalities, so interviews are kept fair for all participants.

3.3. *Addressing powerful and authoritative personalities*

Novice researchers often meet up against challenges when interviewing participants. Issues can arise when a researcher interviews participants who have a powerful

or authoritative personality. Marshall and Rossman (2016) cautioned about interviewing persons with powerful or authoritative personalities, as the interview and the results can morph to address the participants' wishes and perspectives, thereby taking control of the focus group. The best strategy is to stay focused on the focus group interview questions.

The authors of this paper have a great deal of experience interviewing people; not everyone has had that opportunity. Therefore, sometimes thinking quickly works and sometimes it does not, which is why a researcher would want to build in an opportunity for follow-up questions into an interview protocol. In one study, one of the authors had asked the owner of the organization to answer a question regarding a violation of a company policy regarding discrimination against a co-worker. He was very uncomfortable with the question and his reaction was to frame his answer in a religious perspective rather than a legal one – doing unto others, so to speak. The author let him frame his answer in that manner and was able to get the answer she needed. A skilled interviewer knows how to mitigate the challenges of interviewing powerful and authoritative personalities who hijack the data collection process. This is influenced by several factors; some of which can be controlled by the researcher and some not. Using a casual environment, and one which promotes relaxation, with free discussion, can balance focus group interactions.

4. Analyzing the focus group data

The researcher plays a key role in the data analysis phases of the study (Draper & Swift, 2011). It is imperative that interpretations represent those of the participants and not of the researcher (Fields & Kafai, 2009). It would be impossible to remove all bias because researchers are human beings. Rather, the researcher should mitigate bias the best they can (Amerson, 2011; Chenail, 2011). As Denzin (2009) pointed out, there are no common descriptions of a participants' world; therefore, as novice researchers, it is important to record everything during data collection. Remember that member checking is not about the participants' review of the transcripts, but instead the researchers' synthesize of the meaning of what was said and then returned to the participant with the interpretation to ensure that the meaning was captured. It can be stated that researcher bias, whether implicit or explicit, can contaminate the validity of the study results (Vicsek, 2010). Sensemaking is pertinent to use, as it includes an understanding of perceived signals, as well as non-signals that may come to the surface in a focus group interview.

4.1. Sensemaking

Sensemaking is an act in when individuals communicate and make sense together framed by a common culture (Marshall, 2014). It is a behavior that is about transforming the meaning about an event (Dana et al., 2013). Moreover, when a change occurs,

the framing and the communication practices adapt (Moon, 2009). Some adaptations encourage innovation, and some discourage deviation from the status quo (Thurlow & Mills, 2009). Researcher bias can have an impact on the study results and the interpretation of them (Fields & Kafai, 2009). Sensemaking occurs between two or more people as they work towards a common definition of concepts to communicate (Abolafia, 2010). Moreover, sensemaking has also been defined as a *shared narrative construction* (Abolafia, 2010) or *collective negotiation*, where two or more people find a common ground, as it is important to a novice researcher to recognize their own personal role in the study and mitigate any concerns during data collection (Denzin, 2009). If the meaning of the participants' input is captured successfully, then the researcher and participant have engaged in *sensemaking* (Abolafia, 2010); coming to a common understanding regarding what was said.

Sensemaking favors plausibility over accuracy and sensemaking is an ongoing process without an end in sight (Thurlow & Mills, 2009). We recognize that participant storytelling can quickly become problematic because of time constraints. It is best to be vigilant when allowing participants to tell a story because the data can quickly morph into unintended directions. Therefore, follow-up and probing questions are important to bring the focus group interview back on track, and to be able to collect data to answer the research question. Researchers need to be sensitive to concerns about questions that are too open and vague and to where participants will need to be protected. Storytelling is a technique that is used in ethnographic research and is best utilized using *McCormack's Lens* (McCormack, 2000a, 2000b). Moreover, the use of storytelling in data collection brings up the concept of *crystallizing*, as opposed to methodological triangulation, thorough recognizing that there are many sides from which to hear a story and understand the perspective of the participant (Dibley, 2011). Bear in mind the language of the focus group questions in relation to the participants.

4.1.1. Participant language

Jargon and dialects with slang included, have the potential to misconstrue meaning via researcher interpretation. For example, one author misinterpreted the word "pop" as a sound, when the participant's meaning was referring to a simple soda drink. The author was studying nutrition, and the participant was simply describing soda. These are completely different meanings, that, would have differencing data to analyze. Through the participant review method of validation (also known as *member checking*), one can ascertain the meaning of certain jargon words (Brett et al., 2007). As such, it is extremely important as the researcher to use member checking for foundation of meaning from slang use. Moreover, the researcher should share any interpretations with the study participants to ensure that the words are correctly interpreted as well as filling in gaps to enhance understanding of the intent of the jargon (Holloway et al., 2010).

Another author conducted a focus group interview with employees who worked in the packaging and shipping department of a manufacturing facility. When discussing

the use of a ‘truck and a pup’ (semi-truck with attached trailer), it was understood by everyone what that jargon meant. The author had at one time worked in a shipping department and understood the common jargon used but clarified through member checking that everyone understood what was meant, early in the focus group discussion, so that everyone was on the same page. The researcher should have an adequate knowledge of the focus group topic. Scholars can use their knowledge to properly facilitate the focus group. Kitzinger (1995) found focus group facilitators can encourage further explanation or viewpoints of participants in the case of a discrepancy. Sagoe (2012) noted that the use of an experienced moderator/facilitator is useful to keep the interview on track and to ensure that all participants contribute to the discussion. Omojola (2016) suggested the use of two moderators at times to present opposing viewpoints of a topic. Another element to consider is nonverbal communication, which can lead to thicker descriptions and interpretations of the data than if verbal data were used alone.

4.2. *Triangulation/member checking*

The interview questions are the primary source of data collection in a focus group, which allow the qualitative researcher to methodologically triangulate the data obtained (Hall et al., 2019). Researchers may capture answers to back up the recording device during focus group interviews with note taking (Hall et al., 2019). Researchers who use methodological triangulation use data from multiple sources (Fusch et al., 2018; Fusch & Ness, 2015). In addition, triangulation is a data analysis approach that aide in reaching data saturation, which can increase the validity and reliability of the study findings (Fusch et al., 2018; Fusch & Ness, 2015).

Member checking is very useful as it allows the opportunity to follow-up with participants to ascertain that the transcript is accurate, and it is critical to ensure one has captured the *meaning* of the participant’s response (Houghton et al., 2013). This is especially important when studying a group of participants wherein they use a great deal of insider jargon – the military, law enforcement, kitchen staffs, electricians – just about every subculture or group has its own way of phrasing important concepts (Andraski et al., 2014). For qualitative researchers, the transcripts are used for member checking; a means by which researchers can validate meaning, not word choice, with participants (is this what you meant?) to ensure no gaps are left in understanding of the phenomenon (Houghton et al., 2013).

Sometimes participants will agree with what they originally said; sometimes participants will want to expand on their original response (Houghton et al., 2013). Member checking is an important component to enhance the validity of the study results (Carlson, 2010). Moreover, some would state that it also enhances the transferability of the results; however, transferability should be left up to the reader to decide (Marshall & Rossman, 2016). A good illustration of why member checking is so important is to ensure that researchers have a correct transcription of the participant’s response as well as capturing the *meaning* of what was said (Houghton et al., 2013).

Validity is one checkpoint by which researchers can assess whether the study design best answered the research question(s) (Riege, 2003; Ryan et al., 2013). Member checking is a great tool and, if one thinks about it, we member check in our daily lives to ensure that we understand the people we are in a conversation with and communicate with! Human communication is an important aspect of daily living, so it is an important part of research (Redlich-Amirav & Higginbottom, 2014).

Consider for a moment returning to the participant to share the interpretation of the meaning of what was said during the interview and the participant says, “that is not what I meant” and then shares something entirely different. What should the researcher do with this new information – change the transcript, make a note in the transcript, or throw both out? Would the researcher code both answers or just the first or second one? Keep in mind that participants often tell us what we want to hear, hoping to please us, rather than what is their personal truth, mitigating the presentation of themselves into something more socially acceptable (Wooten & Reed, 2000). The answer is to code all data gathered as it is all valuable and worthy of reporting in the findings.

Moreover, sometimes sending the focus group interview questions ahead of time is helpful and applicable and sometimes not. Typically, one does not preview them first with participants, but that is not to say it should not be done depending on the circumstances. If participants are apt to be intimidated by the research process, then sometimes knowing the questions ahead of time is helpful. Often, previewing the questions can give participants an opportunity to craft an answer ahead of time that may not be truthful. This is one of the many reasons why follow up questions and member checking are so critical for the interview process to ensure the validity of the study results.

Whether or not to preview questions can certainly be a judgement call on the part of the researcher. Some researchers may offer a sampling of the questions they may ask during the focus group session. For example, one author offered a sample of one question out of four questions asked during the focus group session. While giving questions in advance may be a judgement call, giving the questions to the participants in real time, while the interview is taking place, aids in the ability for the participants to remember the questions that have been asked. Using the questions as a visual in hand, helps the participants to stay on target considering what they are thinking and discussing. In turn, giving a copy of the questions to the participants aids the author to stay on task with respect to flow and management of the group interview process. One participant in a business setting focus group noted that having a copy of the questions being covered in front of him, helped him tremendously, to be able to hold the paper, glance at it and, then to focus on what was being asked. It aided in his overall recall to participate in the group. As it turned out, the participant was a new parent, that was functioning on a few hours of sleep. Having those questions in hand allowed for the ability to fully engage cognitively and participate in the group discussion.

One of the authors uses post-it-note type flip charts as a visual aid and encourages all the focus group participants to engage in sharing their experiences and perspectives.

Discussing each question in sequence, the author writes the responses on multiple flip charts and clusters the groups brainstorming and initial answers for each question together on the wall. This method often leads to 4–8 poster size sheets for each focus group interview question. After engaging all the participants and filling the walls with initial experiences and perspectives, the author reviews one cluster of flip charts addressing each question in sequence and discusses what the participants previously noted. Before moving to the next cluster of flip charts, the author asks the participants as a group to synthesize the answer for each focus group interview question. This group synthesis leads to synergy and a group consensus. After the focus group the author likes to triangulate the findings with other data to enhance the validity of the findings.

5. Conclusion

As novice researcher, there is the need to question everything in a reasoned and grounded manner to seek the truth about many things. As discussed, one such tool to seek the truth is from the viewpoint of participants in the focus group interview. A skilled interviewer knows how to mitigate the challenges of conducting a focus group where participants can hijack the data collection process. This is not always something that novice researchers can count on because most students do not have experience interviewing or the experience that they do have interviewing is not related to a research study. As noted previously, a focus group is an effective strategy to gather a great deal of data in a short amount of time (Coule, 2013), and an excellent tool to gather multiple perspectives about a given phenomenon (Wagner et al., 2016). Approaching the focus group interview in an organized manner will help alleviate some of the concerns with this type of data collection. By planning the focus group interview carefully, conducting and analyzing the data can produce the desired results.

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